

STATE AND VARNA SOCIETY
IN THE AGE OF THE BUDDHA

c. sixth-fourth centuries BCE | state • surplus • stratification • critique

ANCIENT HISTORY 13
CORE FIRST

1

BOUNDARY, CHRONOLOGY AND CENTRAL THESIS

Core frame: c. sixth-fourth centuries BCE within a longer, uneven c. 600-200 BCE early- historic transition.

Middle Ganga evidence is densest; this is not an all-India census or a sudden 600 BCE revolution.

Topic 11 owns mahajanapadas/Magadha narrative; Topic 14 owns Mauryan imperial administration.

Thesis: territorial power, surplus and social ranking changed together, but through regional and contested processes.

2

SOURCE VOICES, GENRES AND SILENCES

Buddhist Nikaya/Vinaya: social categories and monastic norms; layered oral transmission and redaction.

Jataka/later Buddhist and Jain traditions: rich social memory; chronology and sectarian purpose require control.

Dharmasutra/Grihyasutra: Brahmanical prescriptions for varna, household and penalty; norm is not practice.

Archaeology/coins: settlement, NBPW, forts, craft and circulation; they rarely identify varna or institutions alone.

Method: claim -> named source/material -> inference -> genre, date, region and silence limit.

3

SECOND URBANISATION AS AN URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM

Villages and cultivation -> food, raw materials and labour -> towns and political centres.

Towns/routes -> specialised crafts, markets, credit and political demand -> rural opportunities and extraction.

NBPW is one fine-ware horizon; coins one exchange indicator; fortification one mobilisation indicator.

City test = scale/hierarchy + crafts + exchange + public/defensive works + routes + hinterland.

4

STATE-SURPLUS-STRATIFICATION CAUSAL CHAIN

Ecology + rice/crops + tools + water + labour + settlement growth -> expanded production possibilities.

Household surplus -> tax/tribute/toll/fine + market/credit + rent/service + gift channels.

Resources -> courts, officials, forts, armies, urban specialists and monastic institutions.

Unequal appropriation -> gahapati/setthi influence, dependent labour and sharper status differences.

Qualification: iron enabled, institutions, labour and power converted. No single-cause determinism.

5

TERRITORY, CAPITALS, FORTS AND LAYERED SOVEREIGNTY

Jana/kin authority -> janapada territoriality -> larger competing states with claims over settlements, routes and people.

Capitals concentrated court, defence, storage, exchange and communication; founding dates remain source-specific.

Fortifications indicate labour mobilisation and insecurity; not absolute rule over every surrounding household.

Local clan elites, village heads, corporate bodies and household power survived inside expanding states.

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MONARCHY AND GANA-SANGHA

Monarchy: dynastic king/court -> concentrated command, succession politics, ministers, army and patronage.

Gana-sangha: restricted ruling-clan corporate body -> chief, council/assembly and shared elite authority.

Santhagara and salaka suggest procedure; they do not preserve one universal constitution.

Both extracted resources, punished, negotiated and fought; neither offered universal citizenship.

Exam trap: ancient republic = oligarchic and restricted, not modern democracy.

7

OFFICIALS, TAXATION, ARMY, LAW, JUSTICE AND ORDER

Texts mention ministers/amattas, mahamattas, commanders, judges/accountants and village leaders.

Shared title does not prove identical function; never import the full Arthashastra/Ashokan hierarchy backward.

Bhaga/produce shares, bali, tolls and fines varied; named fractions are prescriptions, not audited uniform rates.

Organised forces and forts show coercive capacity; exact pre-Mauryan standing-army totals are insecure.

Status-sensitive legal norms are visible; actual adjudication by rulers/agents remains poorly documented.

8

AGRARIAN EXPANSION, TOWNS, COINS AND CORPORATE ECONOMY

Land held overlapping cultivator, household, village, chief/king and revenue claims; no one uniform ownership regime.

Punch-marked coins + Pali terms kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, pada, masaka, kakanika -> uneven monetisation.

Barter and payments in kind continued; coin circulation does not identify one issuer or universal money use.

Vanija, artisans and shreni/puga/nigama indicate trade and guild-like association with source-layer limits.

Urban-rural exchange linked food, craft goods, forest products, credit, transport and state demand.

9

VARNA IDEOLOGY, JATI AND STATUS PRACTICE

Varna = broad Brahmanical prescriptive hierarchy; jati = context-sensitive birth/kind/lineage/social group.

Occupation, kinship, wealth, political office and region intersected but did not equal varna or each other.

Brahmana-Khattiya relation combined rank contest with ritual-political cooperation and patronage.

Vaidhya does not equal every merchant; vedas, gahapati and setthi map imperfectly onto prescription.

Shudra subordination is clear in norms, but every worker, artisan, slave or forest person was not automatically Shudra.

10

HOUSEHOLD ELITES, LABOUR, DEPENDENCY AND EXCLUSION

Gahapati/grihapati: substantial household/property-holder, often agrarian; not every ordinary householder.

Setthi/shreshthini: urban business, credit or corporate elite; overlaps with but is not synonymous with gahapati.

Kassaka cultivators varied; kammakara/bhataka mark hired/service labour; dasa/dasi mark dependent or unfree status contextually.

Debt, capture, birth and service created different dependencies; no reliable population proportions survive.

Chandala, Nisada and pukkusa show stigma/exclusion in specific sources, not a finished timeless caste schedule.

11

HOUSEHOLD, PROPERTY, PATRIARCHY AND WOMEN

Patrilineal continuity, controlled marriage and male inheritance privilege structure many normative texts.

Women nevertheless worked, managed resources, gave gifts and appeared as householders, patrons and urban actors.

Ambapali = wealthy ganika/donor; Visakha = lay patron; exceptional visibility is not general equality.

Buddhist bhikkhuni and Jain female orders opened renunciant paths but retained admission, discipline and status constraints.

Male-authored elite sources under-record ordinary female labour; silence must be stated, not filled by guesswork.

12

SHRAMANA CRITIQUE AND THE PERSISTENCE OF HIERARCHY

Buddhist, Jain and other renunciants criticised sacrifice, attachment and the moral sufficiency of birth.

Renunciation could cross some household/varna boundaries and create new male and female institutional identities.

Sanghas relied on alms, gardens, protection and gifts from kings, gahapatis, setthis, women and corporate groups.

Rules for debtors, slaves, soldiers and nuns reveal institutional limits; lay patriarchy and stigma persisted.

Verdict: important ethical critique and institutional alternative, not a simple merchant or anti-caste revolution.

13

PERIPHERIES, MOBILITY, DONORS AND CONTROLLED COMPARISON

Forest, hunting, pastoral and tribal groups exchanged products, supplied labour/tribute, resisted and retained autonomy.

State incorporation was graded; route control, tribute and alliances did not equal cultural assimilation.

Wealth, office, migration, skill, patronage and renunciation enabled status claims; birth, debt and stigma constrained them.

Donor records reveal claimed identity and institutional ties, not group-wide mobility; many inscriptions are later.

Later Vedic -> continuity in kinship/agrarian/varna change; Buddha age -> larger states, towns and organised renunciation.

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UPSC ANSWER SPINE AND MAURYAN BRIDGE

Introduction: define the c. sixth-fourth centuries BCE focus, middle-Ganga weight and source problem.

Body 1: second urbanisation and state-surplus-stratification mechanism with NBPW/coin cautions.

Body 2: monarchy/gana, territory, officials, extraction, law and citizenship/exclusion limits.

Body 3: varna versus jati/practice; gahapati/setthi; labour, household, women and peripheries.

Body 4: shramana critique plus persistence; compare Later Vedic trends and regional variation.

Conclusion: pre-Mauryan capacities formed a bridge, not a ready-made Mauryan bureaucracy or inevitable empire.

ANSWER ROUTE • define – evidence – mechanism – social effect – qualification

No Mauryan projection | no modern democracy analogy | no mature-caste back-projection